collecting information on the Congress-party members in Tamil Nadu and Delhi by Sivarasan.[4]

Another name that cropped up during the interrogation was ‘Mahalingam’, a Sri Lankan Tamil who had stayed in Kodiakkarai and organized the movements of Jayakumar, Athirai, Kanagasabapathy and Payas after their arrival from Jaffna. Was he also responsible for the movements of Sivarasan? No one seemed to know. Murugan was brought in and asked the same question. He did not implicate anyone, but, instead, said, ‘Yes, Mahalingam had taken Sivarasan once from Madras to Coimbatore and back.’ Anyone who had come in close contact with the mastermind was considered a prize catch. He was picked up in the wee hours of the next day from his house near the Kodiakkarai beach. Verma understood Murugan was trying to mislead the interrogators. At his behest, two CBI constables gave Murugan a piece of their mind. Murugan kept quiet for a while and then admitted that he knew Mahalingam and that the latter knew Sivarasan well. In fact, Murugan implicated everyone present, as it was common knowledge among the INT group.

After he was picked up, Mahalingam promptly admitted that he knew Murugan, Santhan, Payas and Jayakumar. He could not remember if he had ever seen Sivarasan, though. He had read about Sivarasan in the newspapers but claimed to have had no knowledge of the LTTE’s plan to kill the former Indian Prime Minister. He said he didn’t know if it was the LTTE who did it. But that was the standard offering of everyone when they were caught.

Around the same time, an IB report assessed that the movements of LTTE militants and their landings took place mostly in Nagapattinam, about 300 km from Madras. Nagapattinam was crucial because of the presence of a top-notch smuggler, Shanmugham, who carried out major transportation work for the LTTE.

Criminals, hardcore political activists and rebels can all be dedicated to their causes but facing interrogation by seasoned police officers requires different skills. Very few can withstand their gruelling methods. From his initial denial of ever knowing Shanmugham, Mahalingam eventually confessed to having assisted him often, including the time when Sivarasan